

Anti-Racism in Action: A Speculative Design Approach to Reimagining SIGCHI

Bryan Dosono
eBay, Inc.
New York City, USA

Ihudiya Finda
Ogbonnaya-Ogburu
University of Michigan
Ann Arbor, Michigan, USA

Yolanda Rankin
Florida State University
Tallahassee, USA
yrankin@fsu.edu

Angela D. R. Smith
University of Texas Austin
Austin, USA

Kentaro Toyama
University of Michigan
Ann Arbor, Michigan, USA

ABSTRACT

In this interactive panel, a brief introduction by the panelists regarding their stances on race and HCI will be followed by breakout group discussion in which participants will be prompted to ask themselves what anti-racist actions they can take in their workplaces and in HCI work.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; • **Social and professional topics** → **Computing profession**; **Race and ethnicity**.

KEYWORDS

anti-racism, racism and HCI, speculative design.

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1 INTRODUCTION

When we consider who is represented in the SIGCHI community or among our research participants, the outcomes tell a story of structural and historical racism. SIGCHI was formed by U.S. academics in 1982 [8], a decade in which the United States was proportionally more white than it is today (at 83.1%) [24]. In its early days, SIGCHI membership consisted almost entirely of English-speaking Western-world professionals, especially from the United States, the United Kingdom, and Northern Europe, and those groups were predominantly white for historical and socio-economic reasons. While this explanation provides a historical context of the racial makeup of SIGCHI, it does not justify the current state of affairs that testify to the continued racial inequality that exists among

its membership. For example, one count of the SIGCHI Academy, whose members are recognized for their “substantial contributions to the field of human-computer interaction” [27], suggests that the composition is 93% white, 5.3% Asian, and 1.5% Hispanic or Latina/Latino/Latinx [25]. Even accounting for potential tallying errors,¹ those proportions are nowhere close to representing the racial composition of, say, the United States (61.6% white only, 18.7% Hispanic or Latino/Latina/Latinx, 14.2% Black, 6.0% Asian, 1.5% Native American, Hawaiian, or Pacific Islander, and 25.3% “some other race” or “two or more races” [17])² and definitely not of the world (approximately 60% Asian, 16% white, 15% Black, 5% Middle Eastern, and 12% other [28]).³ Meanwhile, one study found that 73% of the research participant samples in CHI papers from 2016-2020 were drawn from Western countries [21] – those samples are almost certain to be disproportionately white, given racial digital divides [12], researchers’ tendency to sample from university students [1], and racial inequalities within higher education [11, 16].

Though the community has diversified since its early days, both racially and geographically, SIGCHI remains in the long shadow of past racism. As a community that promotes a more global research culture, we still have a lot of work to do. What would it take, for example, for the total SIGCHI Academy to match the current Black representation in the United States of 14.2%? We could do it in 3-4 years if we inducted only Black members during that time. If, instead we name 1 Black person out of 6 inductees each year (as seems more likely), it would take about 100 years. Those are estimates for just one race. One could mistakenly assume that there are “enough Asian/Asian American scholars” in HCI, but there are Asian subgroups who remain underrepresented, and by any global standard, Asians as a whole are not proportionally represented. And of course, there are forms of discrimination beyond numerical representation. In any case, “business as usual,” will not result in swift racial justice. While it is unlikely that many SIGCHI members or conference participants harbor explicitly racist beliefs, the SIGCHI community needs to cultivate a global culture that promotes anti-racism and resists racism in its many forms.

Anti-racism, especially as articulated by scholars of race such as Ibram X. Kendi, is the active expression of ideas or actions that

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¹The authors of that paper have since learned that the count may be 0.7% Black.

²These figures are based on the U.S. Census Bureau’s 2020 descriptions of racial categories. The numbers sum to more than 100% because they are not mutually exclusive.

³Global race data is approximate, because racial categories vary by country, and data is not collected in a uniform way.

decrease racially discriminatory thoughts and outcomes [19]. Crucially, it requires active effort; sitting on the sidelines, as it were, is to support the racist status quo. As Kendi writes,

The opposite of “racist” isn’t “not racist.” It’s “anti-racist.” ... One either allows racial inequities to persevere, as a racist, or confronts racial inequities, as an anti-racist. There is no in-between safe space of “not racist.”

Toward this end, this panel seeks to encourage all of us – panelists and participants – to consider how we can each contribute to the fight against racism in HCI.

2 ORGANIZER STATEMENTS

2.1 Bryan Dosono

As a senior design researcher within the tech industry, I have been able to observe and engage in well-intentioned employee resource groups that promote cultural heritage for folks who mature in different phases of their diversity, equity, and inclusion journey. While organizing social affinity programs – particularly with events that were backed with a budget and executive sponsorship – were an accessible entry point for colleagues to build belonging and community, I often questioned the extent to which these programs moved the needle toward building a more inclusive workplace.

When I reflect on my days as a graduate student, I recall gravitating toward service opportunities that enabled me to directly organize campus-wide heritage months that spotlight the complexity and untold voices of the Asian Pacific Islander Desi American (APIA) experience. Despite facilitating deep conversations among individuals and allies who cared immensely about dismantling systems of oppression, it seemed like the trauma-informed takeaways and provocations of racial reckoning primarily preached to the choir and lacked the traction to permeate across the broader (predominantly white) campus climate. As institutions like SIGCHI have begun the work to identify inequities within our current ways of working, I am hoping that we can develop a shared sense of collective resistance on what it means to be anti-racist as a community through ongoing dialogue and identify measures for tracking our progress over time.

In being a Filipino American male, I live and breathe within a colonized body that grants me certain privileges and denies me of others. Being a researcher to me means that I am privileged to have a platform to amplify, bridge, and connect the dots across diasporic experiences. The heightened awareness of APIA empowerment in my fieldwork inspired me to examine the interlocking relationships between race and decolonization [10]. Reflexively, how can I play my part to ensure marginalized narratives are accessible and inclusive? Knowledge, from the beginning, has and always will be a political construct. Imperial, hegemonic structures dictate what type of content gets published and what does not. I have decided to use my privilege as a researcher to legitimize the lived experiences of marginalized identities by centering their narratives in my everyday work as a researcher.

2.2 Ihudiya Finda Ogbonnaya-Ogburu

There are explicit and implicit challenges with race and ethnicity in computing. Specifically within SIGCHI, several community members have come together to make public statements about these challenges. Yet, as an organization, we have yet to deep dive collectively into establishing policies and actionable approaches to address issues as it relates to race and ethnicity.

As a scholar whose racial and ethnic identity is not overrepresented, my presence in most places as the sole African American woman should be a reminder that our systems are broken. Images, research groups, events, etc., that lack diversity are demonstrations of broken systems and the importance of all community members needing to be intentional and reflective of their part in creating the future of computing. I recognize not all CHI members work toward being anti-racist, but the unchallenged belief and lack of action of individuals who do not see themselves as racist is no longer acceptable, given that individuals who want nothing to do with issues of race and ethnicity are vocal. Our panel provides the community the opportunity to reflect how racism is not only amplified by large incidents, but the smaller moments of bias like choosing who to respond to in emails [4], determining who is qualified or a good fit for a position [18], who is able to come to work as their authentic selves [7] and more. These examples are all moments where bias and discrimination can occur, especially as it relates to race and ethnicity.

While I reflect on my own experiences navigating a career in computing, organizations like SIGCHI have yet to collect data on race and ethnicity [14]. For true change to happen, the SIGCHI executive board needs to collect data to understand the population they are serving. In my opinion, the organization has shied away from understanding the demographics of its members. This is especially concerning because globally most nations take some level of census [22], immigration exists; issues of apartheid, xenophobia, caste, etc., exist around the world, which are all examples of challenges as it relates specifically to race, ethnicity, and nationality. Additionally, global organizations like the United Nations recognize race, ethnicity, and nationality [23] and the challenges they can cause globally. Which leads me to wonder why doesn't SIGCHI have years of data on the demographics of its members, and what colorblind assumptions have been made to ensure the organization runs at status quo.

2.3 Yolanda Rankin

As a Black woman scholar, my intersectional identity gives me a unique perspective of how race, gender and class have shaped the lived experiences of Black women in the HCI community and the field of computing more broadly. Amplifying the voices of Black women and positioning them as knowledge agents means using my power and privilege to acknowledge our humanity, create opportunities for us tell our stories (testimonial authority) and share our experiences so that we can learn what gendered racism looks like, how it manifests within the HCI community, and most importantly, develop strategies and form alliances to resist racism in its many forms. Drawing attention to racial and gender inequalities that exist in the field of computing, my research leverages Black feminist epistemologies, specifically Black feminist thought and

intersectionality, as critical frameworks to address anti-Black racism and gendered racism that Black women in computing contend with on a daily basis.

Though Black feminist epistemologies center Black women's experiences and celebrate their struggle for survival, their resiliency and joy, these critical social theories can be used by anyone who is committed to the uplift, political and economic advancement, and love of Black people everywhere. Black feminist epistemologies are particularly relevant when we scrutinize for whom technology is designed and who gets to design technology. When we think about how most design paradigms reinforce the dominant culture of whiteness and *otherize* Blackness and other non-white cultures, we as a society reap the consequences of racist design practices that devalue a group of people, missing opportunities to develop creative solutions that affirm the needs of a diverse user population. Without honest dialogue about how power operates in HCI and the field of computing, the push for racial equality and social justice in computing remains an elusive goal. It is my hope that this research will contribute to the burgeoning body of critical HCI research that seeks to develop anti-racist policies and practices that protect the humanity and well-being of all people.

2.4 Angela D. R. Smith

Formally, I have been in the tech industry and broader domain for over eleven years. Through each of my positions, there was always one commonality — I was the only Black woman on the team, in the department, or even at the company. These experiences are not uncommon and further illuminate the brokenness in the system for Black Americans, even more for Black women, to enter and thrive in these spaces. The experiences were exhausting; I felt my voice and, often my presence, stymied my ability to successfully navigate these white boy clubs. I felt a familiar feeling as a graduate student, but this time used my voice and my skills, as a researcher and professional, to bring awareness to the ways in which academic institutions and practices were failing their BIPOC students. However, academic institutions never seem to be held accountable and are often making empty promises.

As a Black, female Assistant Professor, I have gracefully accepted this is a cross I will help carry as many have done before me. Instead of shying away from the work, I am using my privileges and the spaces I occupy to shed light on the ways in which structural and systemic factors are denigrating and excluding individuals of color. Most recently, I created and teach a course, Introduction to Social Justice Informatics, in which we specifically focus on identifying how racial, gender, and other inequities are not *normal* or *natural*, but instead the result of a history of injustice. Further, we seek to understand how sociotechnical systems of oppression disempower certain groups. In my scholarship, service, and teaching, I introduce and incorporate Standpoint theory and feminist epistemologies, so my students can understand how their perspectives and positions are shaped by external influences. With each opportunity I undertake, I actively work to resist the status quo. But in reality, it has to be how we can work collectively to make anti-racist actions normalized.

Through my experiences and conversations, I have observed that individuals within SIGCHI recognize the lack of diversity, equity,

and inclusion in its community and scholarship. My hope is that through continued discussions and critical papers, SIGCHI accepts the metaphorical baton and takes the onus from its scholars and practitioners of color, and instead uses its dominant position and prestige to transform its policies, practices, and procedures to allow truly inclusive spaces. These dialogues are a key piece of progress, but without accountability, they remain empty promises.

2.5 Kentaro Toyama

As someone who has occupied senior positions in HCI research, first in industry and then in academia, I am mindful of how much we collectively control the “pipeline” of talent into our field. A common response to questions of diversity in high-tech industry and academic departments, is to blame the pipeline: In 2014, for example, Google wrote, “There are lots of reasons why technology companies like Google struggle to recruit and retain women and minorities... Blacks and Hispanics each make up under 10 percent of U.S. college grads” [5]. But, while it is undoubtedly true that the pipeline itself could be far more diverse, critics have been quick to point out that “the pipeline is more fruitful than tech companies make it out to be” [6], that recruiting practices remain closed-minded [9], and that attrition due to unsupportive professional cultures remains a significant problem [26]. This is as true, I believe, for academic departments as for industry.

In fact, we — as the SIGCHI community — control much, if not all, of the pipeline. As university faculty, we have considerable sway, often direct control, over how undergraduate students are admitted, which PhD students we accept, how students experience STEM courses, how they are advised about careers, how they experience research, how they do their research, whom we hire and promote among our colleagues, how we interact with our colleagues, and whom we nominate and select for awards and fellowships. As industry researchers, we have similar influence over internships, jobs, and workplace culture. And, even for the pipeline prior to higher education, we can do work to affect how young students engage with computing and HCI [13, 29] — in few other professions can research to improve the diversity of the field's K-12 pipeline count as a key part of the job.

Though I have been doing work to support underserved communities since 2000, it is more recently because of my students that I have begun to attend to race specifically. Anti-racist work is challenging, even fraught, and exactly because of that, also rewarding. Much of the learning happens as I question and re-question my own assumptions, about, e.g., the nature of American First Amendment free speech; advising for students whose backgrounds differ from my own; celebrating vs. lamenting partial progress; race in the United States vs. race elsewhere; highlighting minoritized voices vs. overburdening minoritized groups; etc. I have made many mistakes along the way; my hope is that any harms will be outweighed by the contributions.

3 PANEL STRUCTURE

The objective of this interactive 60-minute session is to bring the CHI community together to reflect and discuss anti-racism in the community. At the conclusion of the session, participants will leave

the session having specific actionable steps to take for themselves and others.

We are employing a speculative design approach as a way to consider alternative worlds and future sociotechnical systems that support ideal social contexts [20]. As an HCI method, speculative design expands what realities are imagined by considering alternative futures [15]. Drawing from Ruha Benjamin, a Princeton professor of African American studies, “one way of experimenting with alternatives to the racist status quo is by employing speculative methods” [3]. Therefore, we engage in speculative design thinking with HCI scholars and practitioners to elicit antiracist sociotechnical futures within SIGCHI and the broader HCI community.

We have designed the panel to first allow 5 minutes for individuals to enter the virtual space and get settled. Second, we will provide the authors/facilitators the opportunity to introduce themselves and share examples of what they do to model change within their career and affiliated institutions. Third, participants will be split into breakout rooms to reflect on the questions below individually and as a group:

- (1) How do you identify yourself within the SIGCHI community?
- (2) Given who you are and your different roles and responsibilities, what can each of you personally do within the next few months to improve racial diversity within the SIGCHI community?
- (3) How can we sustain these efforts within the SIGCHI community, the larger HCI community, your department or institution?

After the initial 3 to 5 minutes of quiet reflection, participants will be guided to create and submit digital artifacts sharing their reflections in breakout groups.

Lastly, during the final 20 minutes of the session, all facilitators and participants will come back together to debrief on the activity and share ideas. During the final 5 minutes of the session, the facilitators will state closing remarks and the remainder of the time will be used to connect in the main room or optional breakout rooms.

Throughout the breakout session, participants will be given the opportunity to share their reflections – signed or anonymized – on a collaborative digital artifact which will be available via a URL. We will ask the conference organizers to display the results on conference center screens during the conference.

4 EXPECTED OUTCOMES

As a result of attending the panel and participating in the breakout sessions, participants will have an opportunity to engage in speculative design thinking, reimagining what the CHI community will be like in the next 5 to 10 years. Using the three previously identified thought-provoking questions to engage attendees in self-reflection and guide group discussion, we anticipate the following outcomes:

- (1) A better understanding of how racism operates within SIGCHI and the larger HCI communities;
- (2) Concrete steps that one can take to resist racism;
- (3) A commitment or pledge to call out and fight against racism and racist practices;

- (4) An accessible community of support and information to resist racism in its many forms;
- (5) A collaboratively created digital artifact/display that reflects the vision of what SIGCHI could be in the future.

When we think about CHI 2022’s theme, *Cultivate Community*, everyone can imagine their role in creating a SIGCHI community that not only reflects the diversity of people in the world but also denounces racial inequality, white supremacy, racism and other discriminatory practices that dehumanize any group of people. As individual members of the SIGCHI community who have pledged to be anti-racists, we bring diverse perspectives and experiences in understanding how racism operates within the community. As organizers who are committed to anti-racism, we facilitate this effort as one example of how we choose to use our power and influence to resist racism. However, if we are indeed serious about cultivating a SIGCHI community in which racism does not exist, we must not leave these efforts to a select few. It is imperative that we recognize that we each have the power to instantiate change. In the words of bell hooks [2], “What we cannot imagine cannot come into being.” We implore the SIGCHI community to respond to the clarion call for racial equity and justice. It is in this spirit of love, imagination, and open dialogue that we invite members of the SIGCHI community to join us in reimagining what our community could be, and what concrete steps each of us can take to transform SIGCHI for the better.

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